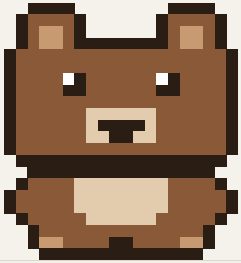
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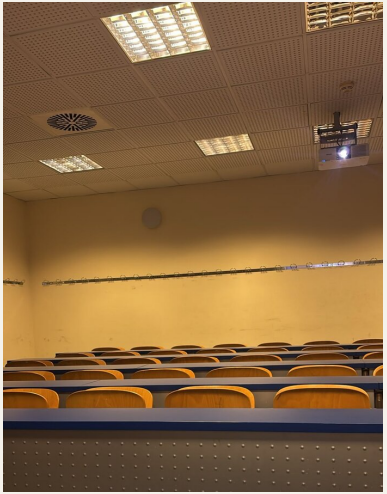
# Policy Evaluation Lab

*Lab 2: A case study, the Carta del docente*



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# About last week's Friday lecture:



# I am fully aware that some of you gave me a notice about it

Gentile Professore,

In riferimento alla presenza per la lezione odierna, La informo che il gruppo di cui facciamo parte la cui presenza è nei primi banchi, oggi è impossibilitato a seguire la lezione, per la restante parte del gruppo non so, e non posso darLe riscontro.
Cordiali saluti

But I could not tell whether anyone else was coming, so I came anyway



PART 1

# Today’s case



# Today: a real exam question

- The case comes from the written exam of a 2025 public competition at the **Ministry of Economy and Finance** (MEF), for officials specialised in the analysis and evaluation of public policies
- This is exactly the kind of task an evaluator in a ministry receives: a policy, a table of administrative data, two questions
- No econometrics needed: what matters is asking the right questions of the data

> **HOW WE WORK**
>
> Groups of 3–4. Two rounds: first the data on implementation, then the design of an evaluation. Each group reports in 3 minutes after each round

# The policy: the *Carta elettronica del docente*

- Introduced by Law 107/2015 (“Buona Scuola”) to support teachers’ continuous training and professional development
- An annual bonus of **€500** for teachers in state schools, to be spent by the end of the following school year
- It can be used freely for four categories: (1) hardware and software; (2) books and magazines; (3) cinema and theatre; (4) training courses
- To use it, teachers must first register on an online platform
- Since 2016 the State has allocated **€380 million a year**
- The Ministry of Education is running a study on the implementation and effects of the policy, and has collected the administrative data in Table 1

Facts as stated in the exam question.

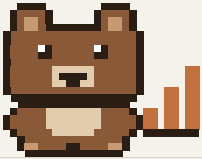
# Table 1: teachers, purchases and spending

| | Teachers (thousands) | | Number of purchases (thousands) | | | | Amount spent (€ million) | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| School year | Eligible | Registered | Hw/sw | Books | Cinema | Courses | Hw/sw | Books | Cinema | Courses |
| 2016-17 | 730 | 630 | 540 | 545 | 56 | 80 | 198 | 38 | 2 | 17 |
| 2017-18 | 737 | 645 | 647 | 1,020 | 160 | 121 | 250 | 66 | 6.5 | 26 |
| 2018-19 | 722 | 655 | 526 | 1,170 | 190 | 104 | 210 | 75 | 8.5 | 20 |
| 2019-20 | 716 | 658 | 599 | 1,250 | 190 | 85 | 244 | 78 | 7.5 | 15.8 |
| 2020-21 | 700 | 650 | 594 | 1,240 | 18 | 57 | 242 | 74 | 0.5 | 10.5 |
| 2021-22 | 702 | 660 | 489 | 1,410 | 122 | 67 | 221 | 84 | 4.6 | 12.5 |
| 2022-23 | 710 | 665 | 472 | 1,637 | 215 | 86 | 212 | 95 | 8.6 | 16 |
| 2023-24 | 760 | 700 | 493 | 1,986 | 320 | 127 | 218 | 113 | 13 | 32 |

Hw/sw = hardware and software; Books = books and magazines; Cinema = cinema and theatre; Courses = training courses. Source: MEF written exam, 31 March 2025. The data were constructed for the exercise and do not necessarily correspond to real values.

PART 2

# Round 1: implementation



# Round 1 (25 minutes): what do the data say?

**THE EXAM QUESTION, PART 1**

Based on the information provided, analyse the main evidence on the implementation of the Carta del docente, indicating which indicators it would be useful to compute, and how

In your group:

1. Which **indicators** would you compute from Table 1? Write down the formula of each one (numerator, denominator)
2. Compute two or three of them for the first and the last year. What has changed?
3. Is there anything in the table that looks odd, or that needs an explanation?
4. What would you tell the Ministry in **three sentences**?

# Round 1: some directions (after the group reports)

**Take-up and use**

- registered / eligible teachers
- total spending / €380 million allocated
- spending per registered teacher, against the €500 cap

**Composition**

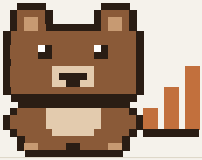
- share of spending by category
- spending per purchase, by category

**Questions the data raise**

- Which category takes most of the money, and which the least?
- What happens in 2020-21, and why?
- Can spending per registered teacher exceed €500 in some years? What would explain it?
- Do these numbers measure **training**, or only **spending**?

PART 3

# Round 2: effectiveness



# Round 2 (25 minutes): did it improve teaching?

> **THE EXAM QUESTION, PART 2**
>
> Illustrate which strategy could be adopted, and which other data would be needed, to evaluate the effectiveness of the Carta del docente in terms of improving the educational offer

In your group:

1. What is the **outcome**? “Improving the educational offer”: how would you measure it?
2. What is the **counterfactual**? Every eligible teacher gets the card: who could play the control group?
3. Which **design** from Weeks 2–4 could work, and under which assumption?
4. Which **data** would you ask the Ministry for?

# Round 2: some directions (after the group reports)

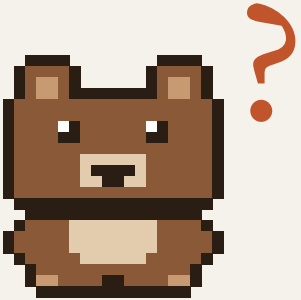
- **The theory of change**: money → purchases → more or better training → better teaching → students learn more. Table 1 only covers the first link
- **Deadweight**: would teachers have bought the same books and computers anyway? Then the card is an income transfer, not a training policy
- **No natural control group**: all eligible teachers receive it, every year. Look for teachers who are **not** eligible, or for differences in timing or rules, and ask whether they are comparable
- **Outcomes beyond spending**: hours of certified training, participation in courses, student results, school self-evaluation reports; linked teacher by teacher

> The data in Table 1 measure **outputs**. The question asks about **outcomes**. That gap is the whole exercise

# Wrap-up

- Evaluation starts before the data: **what is the policy for**, and what would success look like?
- Administrative data are excellent for monitoring implementation; on their own they rarely answer “did it work?”
- A universal policy, given to everyone, is the hardest to evaluate: the design has to be thought of **when the policy is designed**

> **THIS WEEK**
>
> Ex post evaluation as an approach: evaluation questions, theory of change, choosing a design, reading an evaluation critically



# Questions?

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